



Cover photo from the original story

An Enterprise in Harmony

Renewable solutions for rural vulnerable communities

By UNDP Sri Lanka · January 24th, 2025

This clean PDF summarizes the UNDP Sri Lanka story about two agri-entrepreneurs in Kalpitiya whose long-running partnership combines ethnic harmony, farming innovation and renewable energy support.

Communities in isolation

The story begins by reflecting on how some rural areas in Sri Lanka can feel separated by language, religion and ethnicity. Against that background, it presents Shashika and Rikaz as an example of cooperation across community lines.

The two men grew up near each other in Kalpitiya, Norochcholei. Shashika started farming from a young age, while Rikaz entered farming later and brought an entrepreneurial approach and overseas connections.

A partnership of trust

Their friendship has continued for nearly two decades. They began with two small plots and a single buyer, and later expanded into a business that owns or manages more than 50 acres and buys produce from over 50 farmers in the district.

Today, their enterprise exports close to 20,000 kg of vegetables each month to buyers in the United Kingdom and France. The story highlights their openness to technology,

younger talent and inclusive hiring practices.

Their partnership is presented as a local example of unity, trust and practical cooperation across ethnic and religious boundaries.



Shashika and Rikaz, as pictured in the original story

Investing in role models and good examples

The article links their progress to the project “Enhancing Food and Energy Security through the promotion of Green Technologies & Renewable Energy for wider uptake among Vulnerable Smallholder Farmers in Sri Lanka.” The project is implemented through UNDP’s Climate Promise initiative with funding from Japan through the Japanese Supplementary Budget.

Through this support, Shashika and Rikaz received a grid-tied, solar-powered containerized cold room. The unit can store up to 5,000 kg of produce, is powered by a 10 kW solar PV system and includes a backup generator.

The cold room helps them reduce spoilage and buy larger quantities from local farmers. The solar system is described as saving them more than LKR 200,000 monthly, while strengthening security for smallholder farmers who need reliable buyers.

Reducing losses and improving market access

With cold storage available, they can accept more crops from farmers even when an immediate buyer has not yet been confirmed. This makes a major difference for perishable crops such as runner beans and moringa leaves.

The story notes that after receiving the cold room, the team planted a large moringa crop close to the storage facility because moringa leaves need quick cooling to maintain export quality.



Produce sorting and handling at the supported facility

Inclusive enterprise

More than half of the staff are women, and the business involves workers from different communities and backgrounds. The article presents this inclusive approach as part of the enterprise's value, alongside its commercial growth.

Shashika and Rikaz are shown as role models for surrounding farming communities: they demonstrate that agriculture can still be profitable when supported by innovation, clean energy and market-focused thinking.

Bigger-picture impact

The wider message is that clean-energy investments can do more than reduce electricity costs. In this case, renewable energy supports food security, reduces post-harvest loss, improves smallholder income opportunities and strengthens social cohesion.

The story closes by emphasizing that investing in determined people with progressive attitudes can help create sustainable development in rural vulnerable communities.

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